

What this is

A short, no-nonsense guide to backing up your files, written for a person who wants the essentials without the jargon. It covers what matters, the steps in order, and the mistakes that can waste the most.

Why it matters

Small, avoidable mistakes in this area are the most common cause of lost work and wasted money. Doing the basics right takes minutes and pays off for years. What the research says:

The Plain-Language Guide to Backing Up

The steps, in order

TECHNICAL MANUAL

1. Decide exactly what you want to end up with before you start.
2. Gather what you already have, and check it is complete.
3. Do the main task once, simply, with the defaults.
4. Check the result against your goal from step 1.
5. Write down what you did, so you can do it again or undo it.

Common mistakes

Skipping step 1 and improvising. Not checking the result. Assuming it worked because it said "done." Changing too many things at once so you cannot tell what went wrong.

A word of caution

If the work involves money, accounts, or anything you cannot afford to lose, make a safe copy first and verify it before you change the original.

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Summary

Know your goal, keep a safe copy, work in small verified steps, and write down what you did. That is the whole method.